

SETU Survey of Gen AI Use in Research for the Academic Year 2024/2025

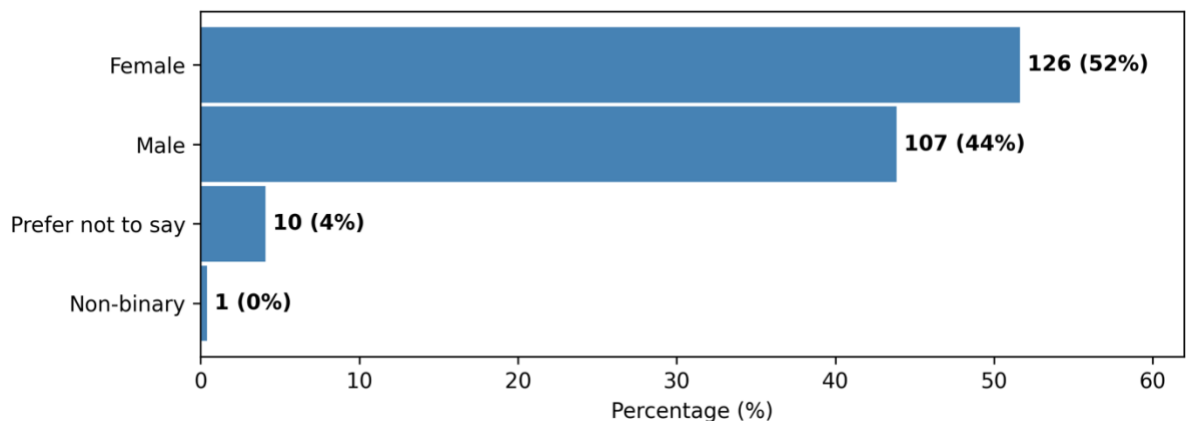
Executive Summary by Working Group on Gen AI in Research

Description

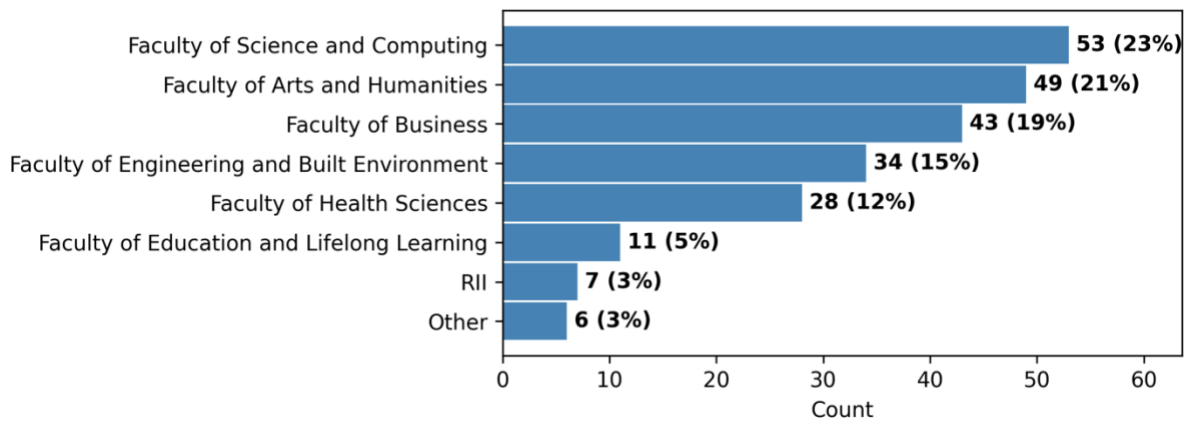
On 11 June 2025, the Working Group on Gen AI circulated an anonymous survey to all staff and postgraduate research students requesting all those that engage in, or support, research (researchers, supervisors, research support staff, research managers and postgraduate research students) to complete the survey. Only a small number of postgraduate participants responded following the initial email. To increase the number of postgraduate respondents, we sent out an additional email on 30 June 2025, in which students were offered the option of entering into a raffle to win a number of vouchers. The survey was closed on July 7, 2025. In total 273 SETU staff and postgraduate students participated. The results of this survey will be used to inform future AI strategy, policy and training. The survey was reviewed and approved by the SETU Research Ethics Committee prior to sending out (Ref: SETU/REC/24/25/088).

Demographics

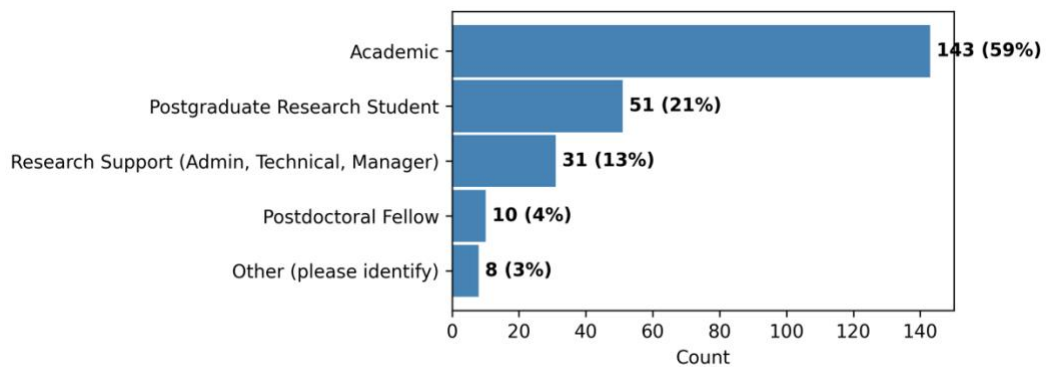
- 273 researchers participated:



- There was representation across all faculties:



- 51 (21%) of respondents were postgraduate students and 106 (43%) of respondents were supervisors of postgraduate students.

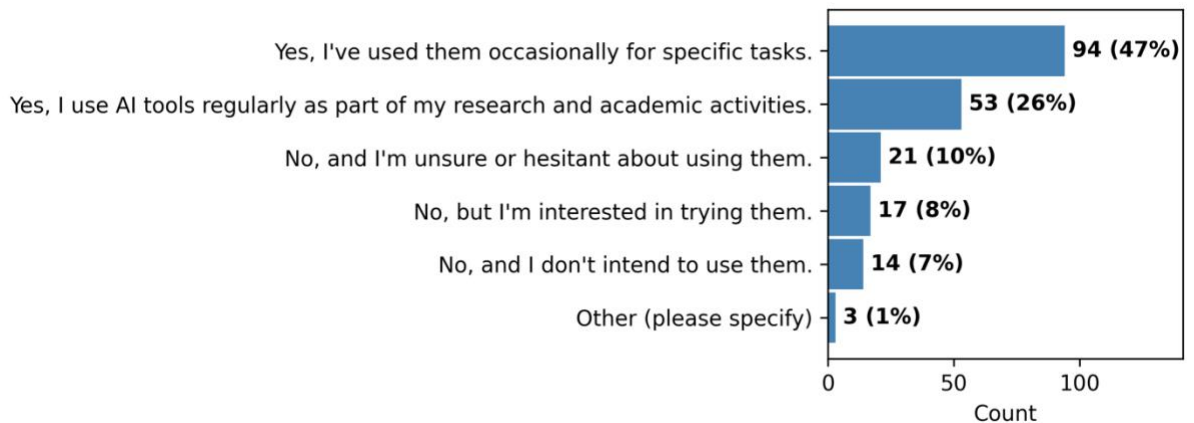


Use

Adoption (Q8)

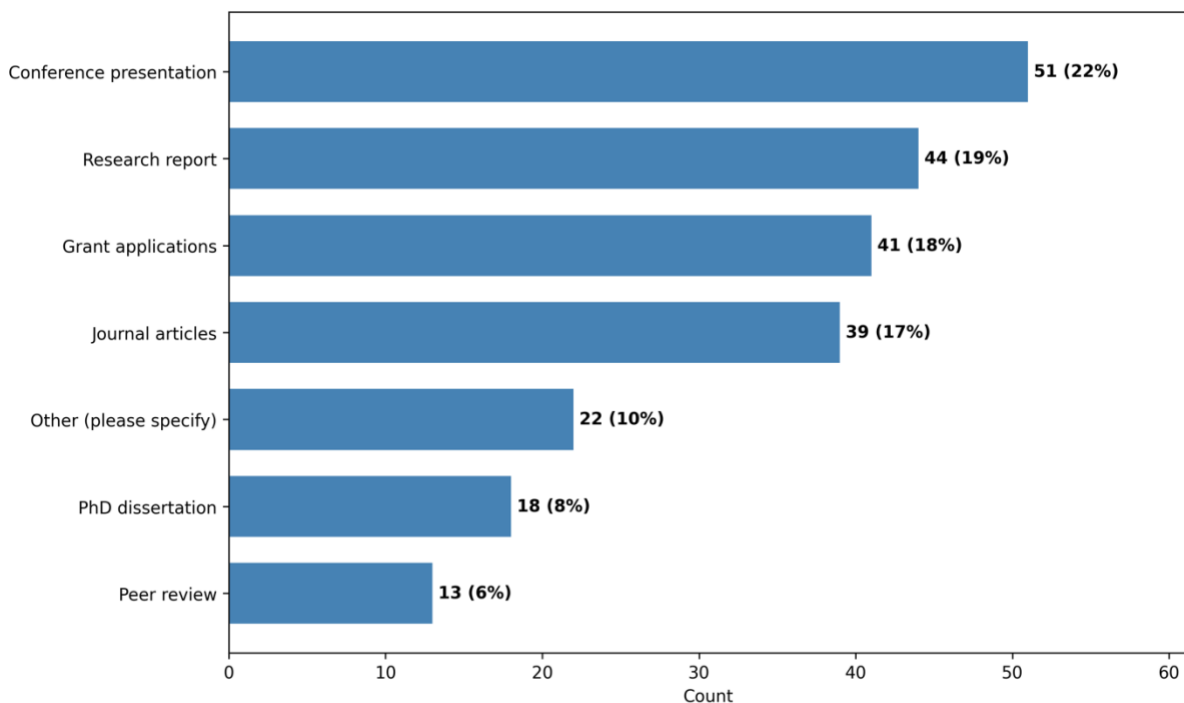
- **Occasional use dominates (47%):** Most respondents use AI tools occasionally for specific tasks.

- Regular use is much lower (26%) and a notable group is hesitant or uninterested (10%).



Use Cases – Research Outputs

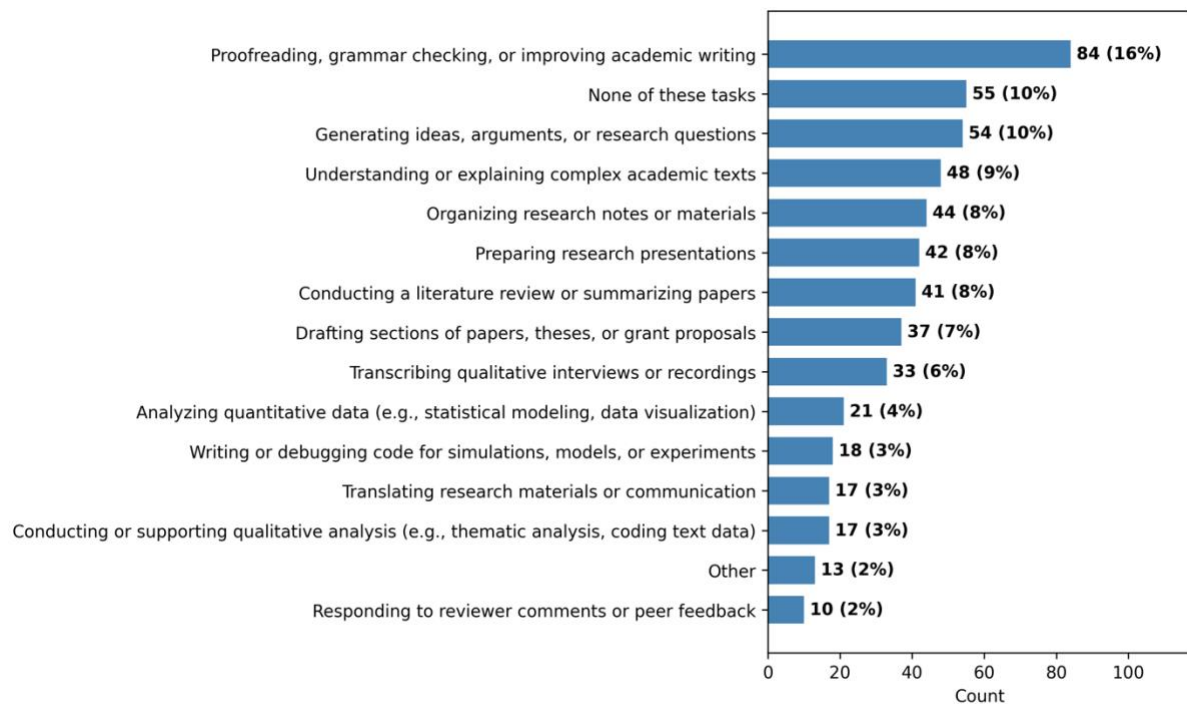
There is a small cohort (51 respondents/22%) that are using Gen AI tools to help with conference presentations, research reports, grant applications and journal articles.



Use Cases – Research Tasks

The most common research task Gen AI is used for is proofreading, grammar checking and academic writing (16%), followed by generating ideas, arguments and research questions (10%), then for explaining or understanding topics (10%). A similar proportion didn't use it for any research task (10%). Note that this list is the Credit

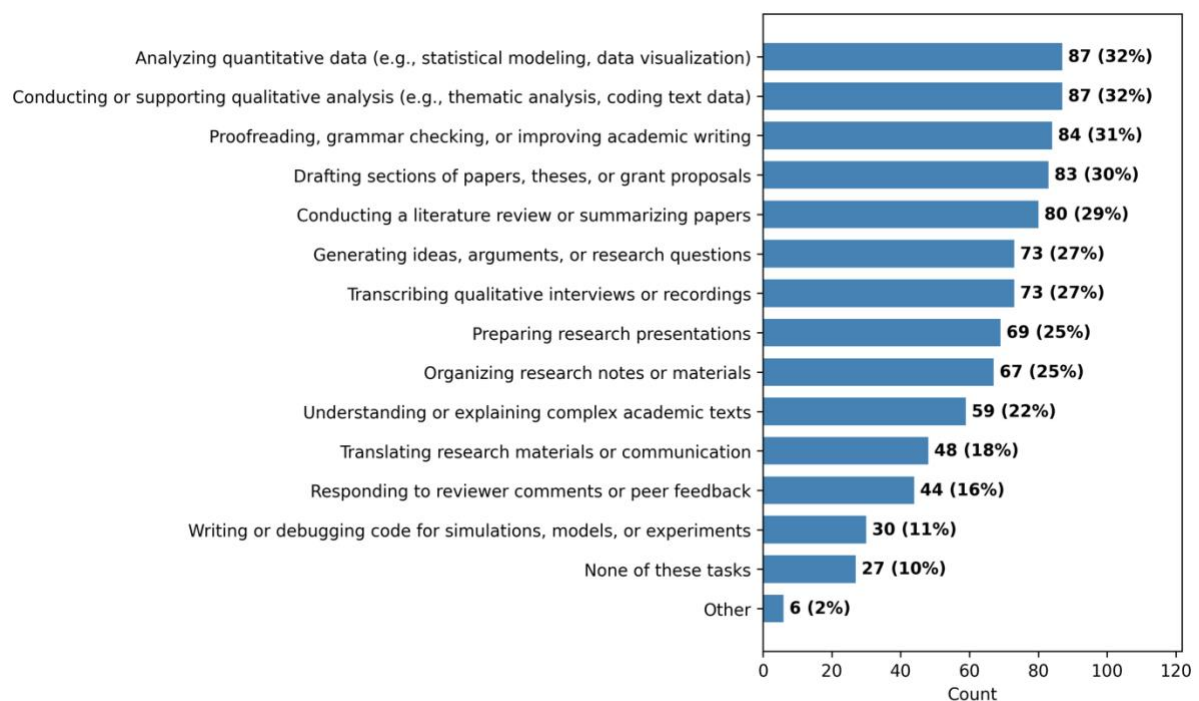
taxonomy, the ANSI/NISO standard that covers most major research tasks¹



Training

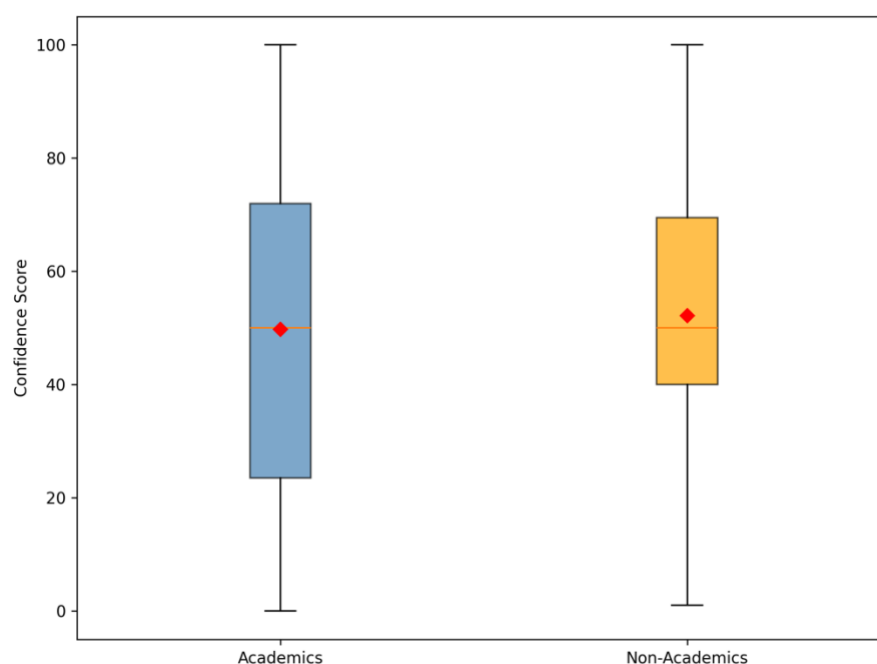
Participants were asked about which research tasks they would like training on how to use AI. Quite a notable cohort expressed the need for training on how to use AI to conduct or support qualitative analysis (32%) and for analysing quantitative data (32%).

¹ <https://credit.niso.org/>



Confidence Levels

- Average confidence in using AI tools to complete research tasks is **low (mean of 50.7 on a 0–100 scale)**. This did not vary significantly between academics and non academics (postgraduates and postdocs):



- Supervisors' ability to supervise the use of AI among their masters and PhDs had a mean of just 39.3 on the same scale and a similar value for undergraduates (42.7).

Acknowledging Use of AI

- Only a small number say that they always acknowledge the use of Gen AI (35) in their research work, a larger number say that they sometimes (55) or never (40) acknowledge AI.
- There were low confidence levels (50.2 mean) in participants' ability to acknowledge AI use in research.

Tools

- ChatGPT dominates as the most used tool (138/42%), followed by Copilot (57/18%) and Gemini (41/13%).
- Research assistant tools like NotebookLM (8%), SciSpace (3%), and Elicit (4%) are used very little.
- 51 (31%) of respondents have a paid subscription to one or more of these tools.
- Among paid users, ChatGPT Premium (55%) is by far the most common subscription (all other tools have between 1% and 4% users).

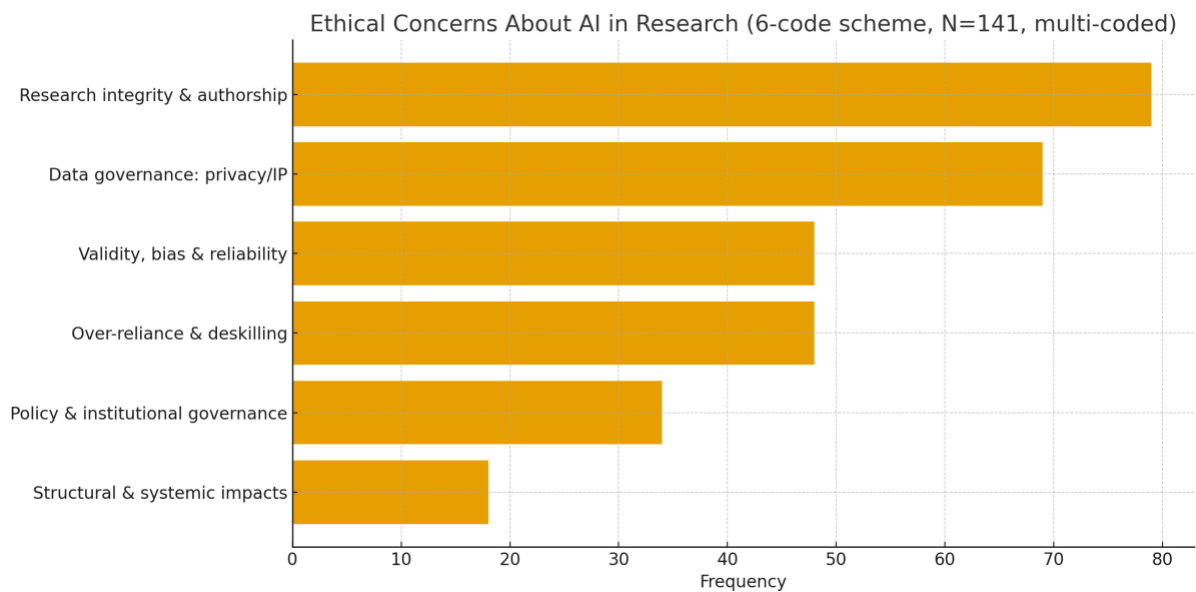
Barriers to Adoption

- Cost, privacy, guidance, and knowledge gaps are the biggest barriers to adoption.

Ethical Concerns

Respondents were asked the following open question "what are your main ethical concerns in relation to the use of AI in your research?". The following themes

emerged:



1. Research integrity & authorship (plagiarism & originality)

Concerns about work not being the author's own; plagiarism; blurred authorship; fairness in assessment.

Examples: *"Identifying and trusting the unique/original contribution to knowledge by research students"; "Students see very little logic to writing a literature review or indeed a non-AI generated methodology...the days of thesis being capstone for a masters or phd are gone."; "concern is that my PhD students who are required to produce original work do not appear to understand that using AI is engaging with a third party in the production of their research and writing"; "I supervise postgraduate students. If they use AI I am not in a position to detect it"*

2. Data governance: privacy, confidentiality, IP & copyright

Risks of sharing non-public data with third-party tools (GDPR/confidentiality), plus ownership/credit/fair-use concerns and model training on copyrighted works. Example: *"One genuine ethical concern for me is data privacy... I cannot be sure where that data ends up or how it is used."; "giving AI tools access to potentially identifiable data"; "I believe AI LLMs are harvesting creative output in an unethical manner"*

3. Validity, bias, reliability & transparency of AI outputs

Accuracy/hallucinations, reliability, hidden bias, and lack of explainability or provenance. Example: *"Data in models is out of date..."; "AI tools, especially LLMs, can produce convincing outputs without clear justification, and that makes it easy to generate results or summaries that seem authoritative but haven't been properly*

vetted”

4. Over-reliance & deskilling (loss of critical/analytical thinking)

Outsourcing thinking; reduced depth of understanding; diminished scholarly skills. *Example: “Students won’t learn to write and think properly.”; “lack of ability in students to critically evaluate and use effectively AI and an overreliance on it that stifles originality and confident in their own judgement and abilities”*

5. Policy & institutional governance (rules, compliance, detection)

Uncertainty about what is permissible; lack of consistent guidance; uncertainty about detection tools. *Example: “All – what is permissible and what is not.”; “We are not able to guide them properly due to weak academic guidance and boundaries on offer from academic leaders in the institution”; “knowing where the college stands on it and whether or not detection tools are accurate and how to deal with use of AI used to complete entire assignments...”; “I am using AI as main tool in my research and i do not have any institutional guidelines how much extent it is ethical to use AI in my research”.*

6. Structural and systemic impacts (environmental, commercial & social)

Commercial capture of research outputs; profit driven priorities vs. academic values; impact on research careers; environmental sustainability concerns.

Example: “Environmental impact of the huge amounts of energy required to power AI tools.”; “most AI tools are profit driven and so ethics and politics are minimal concerns - we are handing over more power to corporations”; “destroying the career pathway of upcoming researchers”

7. Emerging/minor these - organisational culture & dialogue

A small number of respondents highlighted widening gaps between staff who advocate for AI and those who resist it, noting that discussion feels difficult and norms are unclear. *Example: “resistance in the use of AI among colleagues”; “the variety of opinions among other academics around what is acceptable or not”; “gaps between staff in terms of proponents and those who are against it. Difficult to discuss”.*

Additional Comments

Respondents were given the opportunity to provide other comments. Here are some notable themes in the comments:

1. **Call for clear, consistent institutional policy and guidance (across UG/PG/Doctoral)** Many respondents want unambiguous rules on what uses are acceptable, how to disclose AI, and how to supervise student use.
2. **Training and capacity-building—practical, discipline-specific, and ongoing**
Requests included hands-on “how to use it well,” discipline-specific sessions and training for supervisors.
3. **Assessment integrity: plagiarism, supervision challenges & detection tools**
several noted difficulties supervising undergraduate use and mistrust of detectors.
4. **Tool governance & resourcing (licenses, support, ‘super-users’)**
Multiple comments asked for institutionally funded licences, bundled support, and named champions in faculties to help with adoption.
5. **Mixed stance on adoption—from strong caution to strong embrace**
Views range from “AI is crippling academia / take a strong stance against use” to “AI is here to stay—learn to use it well.”

Conclusion

In terms of AI adoption and the tools used, ChatGPT dominates. This raises ethical concerns that staff and students could be inputting intellectual property (e.g. unpublished research data), confidential or personal data into ChatGPT where their data is not protected and could be shared with others. The results and comments also suggest there is a need for clear information around what institutional licences exist and a need for more institutional licences (e.g., Gemini and Notebook LM licences). This could improve the quality of research outputs, protect IP and sensitive data and remove one the biggest barriers to adoption identified in the survey: cost. This would also support more equal access to AI tools for all staff and students.

It is concerning that a notable number of respondents said that they only sometimes or never acknowledge the use of Gen AI in their work. Considering that there were only moderate confidence levels among participants in their ability to acknowledge AI use, this would suggest there is a lack of understanding of how to acknowledge and that clearer guidance and training is needed on how, and when, to acknowledge AI use within different aspects of research.

In relation to confidence levels, it is striking that the lowest confidence levels relate to the ability of supervisors to guide students in their use of AI tools. Supervisors need training and clearer guidance on how to ensure responsible use of AI among postgraduate students.

Overall, we can see that there is high occasional use which would suggest a large number are curious about these tools, but AI is not yet deeply integrated within research at SETU. The most requested training by participants was in using AI to assist with qualitative and quantitative data analysis.

Future surveys should consider examining awareness of current SETU position and guidelines on AI use and how many have completed AI literacy training.